

Introduction: "The Missing Feminist Revolution" Symposium

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Feminist sociologists keep going back to Barrie Thorne and Judith Stacey's 1985 exploration of the missing feminist revolution in sociology (Stacey and Thorne 1985) and their 1996 (Stacey and Thorne 1996) question, "is the feminist revolution still missing?" This fascination with feminist progress suggests that former feminist revolutionaries are not entirely satisfied or co-opted, even though now quite comfortably established in academic jobs, or happily retired. Their academic daughters are asking new questions and working with new theoretical frames that were not available 30 years ago, adding new possibilities for feminist incursions into the sociological mainstream. The articles in this symposium give varying answers to the 1996 question and insightful comments on what has changed and what still needs to be done. In this introduction to the symposium, I comment briefly on the articles and discuss my own answers to the question of the missing revolution.

Christine Williams, as editor of *Gender & Society*, is particularly well situated to identify what is still missing. One missing element is convincing explanation of the remarkable persistence and stability of gender inequality. Williams suggests that we look again at functionalism for what it might contribute to understanding stability and lack of change. As she says, it is necessary to explore the "social and psychological attractions of gender for women (as well as men) to make sense of the political backlash against feminism" (p. 455). Another missing element is theory adequate to deal with increasing inequality in this time of "neoliberal free-for-all" (p. 457). Williams favors a feminist return to Marxist analyses of class because an exclusive focus on gender discrimination is not sufficient to illuminate increasing class inequalities. Other authors, unsurprisingly, do not see a journey to the past as the way to the future.

Judith Lorber argues that although feminist sociologists have developed a new and important paradigm, "it has been very difficult, if not impossible, to get mainstream sociology to use the concept of gender as a building block and organizational principle of social orders and social institutions . . ." (p. 449). She attributes this resistance to the tenacity of the belief that gender is fundamentally a function of biology. She proposes abandoning binaries such as female and male and deconstructing categories such as gender, physiological sex, and sexuality to discover multiplicities and to strengthen intersectional analyses. Lorber concludes with her commitment to a future sociology that includes "a structural gender analysis of all social phenomenon. . . ." (p. 452).

Raka Ray also takes a clear position on the missing feminist revolution: "The problem of seeing feminist theory as sociological theory is still with us despite clear wins in the institutionalization of gender as a field." The other authors of articles in this symposium would agree with that. Ray discusses important shifts in feminist thinking as well as the impacts of poststructuralism, postcolonialism or transnationalism, and the relationship of theory generation to geographic location of the theorist. She suggests that there are resistances within sociology to these three transformations in theoretical thinking and that these resistances inhibit

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further development of the feminist revolution. I won't repeat Ray's complex and persuasive argument, but will only say that she makes a good case that resistance to these new ideas is a barrier to ongoing development of feminist thought in sociology. There has been a feminist revolution of sorts, she thinks, but now it is stymied by these resistances.

As a historian, Leila Rupp takes an outsider's view, comparing the successes and failures of the feminist revolution in sociology and history. Feminist historians wanted to "change the 'master narrative'—to shift the paradigm" (p. xx) just as feminist sociologists did. Poststructuralism, the idea of intersectionality, and postcolonialism have also pushed feminist history in new directions. In spite of the development of sophisticated feminist theory, Rupp suggests that perhaps the idea of a feminist revolution is no longer appropriate and that perhaps we should think in terms of "ongoing skirmishes or contested multiparty elections" (p. xx). Feminist history and feminist sociology have had very similar, intertwined histories over the last 30 years.

Finally, Barrie Thorne and Judith Stacey have each written a reflection on their two articles on the missing feminist revolution, along with comments on the other articles presented here. Barrie Thorne celebrates the flourishing of feminist sociology over the last 30 years, but she also cautions that vitality and creativity may be lost with complete inclusion and legitimacy within the boundaries of the discipline. Creativity is more likely to be nurtured at or outside the boundaries where there are activists and scholars from other places raising difficult questions. Judith Stacey, who is now located outside the boundaries of sociology in a department of "gender and sexuality studies," is one who raises some difficult questions, including why so many feminists should reject the idea that biology contributes to social differences between the sexes. Stacey thus contends with Lorber who sees biological explanations as primary barriers to the inclusion of gender in mainstream theorizing. In concluding her discussion of what we are missing in feminist sociology, Stacey moves outside issues of theory and method to raise an alarm about "the clear and present danger" of contemporary political moves by right-wing neoliberals to repress intellectual freedom in universities, repression that would of course affect feminist scholars and all other radicals.

There is much more of great interest in these articles, which you will discover as you read them. Here, I want to add my answer to the question, is the feminist revolution in sociology still missing? My answer is "yes, it is still missing," in the sense that many of us imagined during the exciting first years of feminist critique and efforts at constructing new theory. In this I concur with all the authors of these articles. The idea of revolution may be misleading and dangerous, as Judy Stacey suggested, but I think it is still useful in standing for fundamental transformation. Feminist sociologists, along with feminists in other disciplines, made basic criticisms of claims of academic knowledge producers to objectivity, gender neutrality, and universality. Feminists argued that such claims were (are) located in privileged male enclaves that provided standpoints from which significant aspects of social life, including women and male domination, were either invisible or insignificant (e.g., Smith 1987). Dorothy Smith and others also argued that the procedures for creating objective, rational, impersonal knowledge are congruent with the procedures for ruling and organizing class societies. Using such procedures replicates the underlying "relations of ruling" even when researchers claim they are challenging those relations. As feminists moved from theorizing sex categories, women and men, to gender relations and domination as societal processes, the implications of a feminist revolution in sociology expanded. A feminist revolution in sociology in the minds of many feminists—I am not claiming that we all thought the same way—would have brought gender into theorizing about all power relations and all social institutions, as most of the symposium authors recommend. This revolution would have changed central conceptualizations of economy, state, class, race, religion, etc., as well as theories of societal structuring and change. This is the revolution that did not happen, as some of the following articles also argue.

The evidence of the failed revolution is abundant in sociology departments, although more abundant in some than in others. It can be seen in course offerings: there may be courses on the sociology of gender or on sexuality and society, but no or little integration of

gendered processes in courses such as those on the environment or on globalization. The failure can be seen in the content of textbooks and reading lists: a theory collection may have one excerpt from a feminist sociologist, but no integration of gender as a principle of societal structuring processes in other chapters. Failure may also be seen in the research interests of faculty, which might include such topics as sex segregation or discrimination studied using large data sets, but no topics such as the role of gendered assumptions and practices in corporate expansion or in the creation of political parties' strategies.

On the positive side, there has been tremendous success in building a new subdiscipline, the sociology of gender. Judith Lorber discusses this as a paradigm shift that has produced an "enormous body of theory and research" (p. xx). Some of this research, primarily quantitative explorations of differences between women and men, is fully legitimated in mainstream sociology. For example, the August 2006 issue of the *American Sociological Review* (ASR) had five quantitative articles dealing with such issues. However, as Lorber also notes, the underlying theoretical insights have not been adopted by the discipline as a whole. I used to think that real paradigm change in the larger world of sociological thinking would come only as the old male generation died off. Unfortunately, there seems to be a young generation just as embedded in that cloistered masculine standpoint as the old generation, and new subdisciplines, such as economic sociology, emerge apparently totally innocent of knowledge about the feminist critique.

Perhaps some of us hoped for too much or for the wrong thing, as some of the symposium authors suggest. Sociology could not be easily transformed because that transformation would mean rethinking many basic concepts, as I noted above, as well as questioning the usefulness of pervasive distinctions such as macro/micro or levels of abstraction. One unified theoretical approach was unlikely to emerge from difficult discussions around such issues. Nor were most sociologists inclined to call into question basic understandings about what they were doing. However, over the intervening years, new critical questions for sociologists, including feminist sociologists, have emerged as historical changes have brought more voices into the discussions and have expanded the boundaries of urgent questions. The articles in this symposium all touch on these issues—intersectionality, globalization, and transnational processes of power and subordination. To this list of issues I, along with Williams, would add the resurgence of old issues such as how to conceptualize class and capitalism and related issues about the extraordinary escalations of inequality, and the role of gender in the creation of inequality and in its consequences on local, national, and global levels. All of these issues help to chart a path for the further development of feminist sociology.

Intersectionality, as a response to the criticism that feminist theory universalized the experiences of white, middle class, Anglo-Saxon women, has been a powerful, but difficult corrective. Thinking in a vocabulary of intersectionality is powerful because it demands that we connect many processes, such as race, gender, class, and sexuality, which previously have been isolated in bounded categories, to see the very complex, interlinked production of inequalities and identities. Thinking intersectionality is difficult because it is not clear how to break down the boundaries of reified categories to show how multiple inequalities are simultaneously reproduced. Each categorical name—e.g., gender or class—represents complex and highly variable social relations, usually simplified as sub-categories—e.g., masculine and feminine or middle class and working class. Instead of engaging in the endless proliferation of categories, some sociologists have turned to the analysis of practices or the active production of inequalities and identities, as Ray points out. This is easiest to do when the researcher or theorist has direct access to practices as a participant observer in an office or a school, for example. But, an office or a school room are not isolated, they are located within multiple other practices and relations that influence and contour the local, routine practices, connecting them possibly to distant practices not easily seen in particular local places. Intersectional analysis must also be historical, for practices always take place in real time, linked to past time. An intersectional approach is complicated and chancy. In sum, I think it is difficult to carry out, which is no reason for not trying.

Globalization and transnational processes of power and subordination are huge topics that feminist sociology needs to pay attention and contribute to. Indeed, as Ray implies, it may be impossible for us to adequately understand gender issues within the United States without an understanding of how life here is connected to and affected by transnational processes. Comparative studies are important: we can learn that ways of organizing social life that seem inevitable are actually contingent and that there are many possible solutions to particular problems. But, I think that understanding transnational processes, including some aspects of "globalization," is even more essential now that we finally see that social relations, including economic relations, do not stop at national borders. New subdisciplines focused on these processes seem to be emerging even among feminists. Consequently, a new issue for feminist sociology is how to keep the dialogue going between feminists who work on transnational issues and those who work, primarily, on issues about gender within the boundaries of the United States and its cultures.

Capitalism and class should, I believe, be subjected to reexamination by feminist sociologists. "Class, gender, and race" has become a litany in feminist work. But the meaning of class is often unclear. Stacey notes the serious problems with Marxist class analysis and Williams notes its absence in feminist analyses. Williams suggests a return to Marxist theory, as I discussed above. I am in total agreement with her, but I think that the solution is not to bring back an unaltered Marxism. As Stacey argues, the labor theory of value has grave theoretical problems as a formulation of the core capitalist relation of domination. Much more is going on. I think that feminist sociologists can, with the help of feminist economists and historians, move toward a feminist historical materialism that builds gender and race relations, nationally and transnationally, along with sexuality, into its understanding of the emergence and present transnational functioning of the complex economic/social relations we call "capitalism" (Acker 2006). I think this would be a new endeavor, not a rehashing of old arguments. And such a theory could be useful in dealing with the neoliberal assaults on progressive and critical forces in academia that Stacey alerts us to.

The question of whether the revolution is missing evokes for me a great deal of reflection about where we feminist sociologists have been, the amazing things we have accomplished in building a new subdiscipline in only 30 years, where we have failed, and where we still might go. Several of the authors bring up the issues of disciplinary boundaries and the many advantages of interdisciplinary work. Feminist sociology has remained so vital partly because many of its practitioners have freely crossed these boundaries, as Thorne points out. Still, organized institutional power still resides in the academic disciplines. Feminists cannot abandon attempts to change those centers of power. Still, the feminist sociology that is most institutionalized, that gets published in the *ASR*, stays rather close to the boundaries of the centers. That may be just as well, for the boundary crossers might be tamed by being brought into the center and it's critical for the future of feminist sociology that they are out there, contending with the ideas of many other boundary crossers from other places.

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